may stand with the establishment, but their ambivalence costs their side dear. This is in contrast to Drupada, whose single-mindedness enhances his value as an ally. The Trigarta, as noted earlier, are its more extreme version. Shalya, Balarama and Rukma are the spectrum of non-alignment to non-involvement. And as for Kunti, her emotional commitments do not preclude a willingness to pay the operational costs of success.

The determining factor, as we all know, is Sri Krishna. He understands the big picture, fashions a strategy accordingly and comes up with tactical solutions at decisive moments. His choices set the direction, whether it is in structural change, shaping sentiment, enhancing brand or creating narratives. By bringing down Jarasandha, he is able to ensure a more favourable balance of power. Whether it is through his own presence or by the sagacious advice tendered, he helps swing opinion in favour of the Pandavas. His diplomatic overtures underline the message of a reasonable power, thereby making his side look the injured party. At key moments – the killings of Jayadratha, Karna or Duryodhana – he is both the motivator and the justifier. He is also the advocate of restraint to the Pandavas, encouraging them to bide their time and acquire the necessary capabilities for a conflict that is inevitable. His may be the voice of reason or the words of caution, but equally it is also the call to action when required. It is not just that he shows the pathway when others flounder. Most important, he does the right thing with full responsibility.

The Mahabharata is as much a tale of ethics as of power. It is Sri Krishna's choices that reconcile these two imperatives. As Indians prepare for greater contributions, they must rely on their own traditions to equip them in facing a tumultuous world. That is certainly possible in an India that is now more Bharat. As we make our choices in a world of all against all, it is time to come up with our own answers. Being an ethical power is one aspect of the India Way.